Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 10 ♥ A K Q J 9 ♦ K 4 3 ♣ 7 5 2	
♠ 5 3 ♥ 6 5 2 ♦ Q 10 5 2 ♣ K Q 9 3	N W E S	♠ K Q J 7 4 ♥ 10 3 ♦ J 8 7 ♣ J 10 4
	♠ 9 8 6 2 ♥ 8 7 4 ♦ A 9 6 ♣ A 8 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	2♥
Pass	3♣	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠K

Your first bid is easy, you say 1♥. But what do you say after partner's 2♥ response?

You have 18 points and partner has 6-10. Doing the math, you total 24-28.

You want to make a bid that will tell partner to bid game if he has 9-10, but will stop at 3♥ if he only has 6-7. Lots of players will bid 3♥ with this hand to make just that invitation. There's nothing wrong with that bid.

But there is an improvement. Bid 3♣ instead. Partner knows you aren't showing him a ♣ suit, why would you do that after agreeing on ♥s? What it means is "Partner I'm inviting you to bid the game if you have maximum, but if your decision is close decide based on ♣s, the suit I could use help in." It is called a **HELP SUIT GAME TRY**. Partner has 8 points and the ♣A and decides that is enough to bid game.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠K.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠K.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 2 : Total = 4

You win the ♠A and pull trumps in three rounds. You need to manufacture one winner and you can see right off the bat that it cannot be manufactured in ♦s or ♣s. However, you **CAN** set up the ♠8.

Lead the ♠10. East must win with his ♠J. Let's say he plays a ♣. Win with dummy's ♣A and play the ♠9, discarding a small ♣. East will take his ♠Q and cash a ♣ trick, but then must let you back in. You enter dummy with the ♦A and discard your ♦ loser on the good ♠8.

It is extra nice when the opponents hand you a contract.

You cannot make 10 tricks unless East's opening lead is a ♠.

Board 2
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A J 6 4
♥ 7 5
♦ A K 7 4 2
♣ 6 2

♠ 3
♥ Q J 10 6 2
♦ 10 8
♣ K J 9 5 3

♠ 10
♥ K 9 8 3
♦ Q J 9 5
♣ Q 10 7 4

♠ K Q 9 8 7 5 2
♥ A 4
♦ 6 3
♣ A 8

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♦	Pass	1♠
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♦	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by South
Lead: ♥Q

You don't quite have the strength for a jump-shift, and in any case sometimes it is better to proceed slowly. So you respond 1♠, knowing partner must bid again.

He does bid again, surprising you when he says 2♠.

All of a sudden your hand has become gigantic. Never mind points, you have only 5 possible losers in your hand and partner has opened the bidding. Surely he can take care of a few of them.

You want to try for slam. **DO NOT BID BLACKWOOD!** With two quick losers in ♦s you would not know what to do if Partner showed only one Ace. You wouldn't know whether the defense could take the first two ♦ tricks or not. A better approach is to use a control bid.

So you bid 3♣. Partner will absolutely know that you aren't bidding a ♣ suit, he knows you have already agreed on ♠s. He will take you to be showing first round control in ♣s, probably the ♣A.

Partner bids 3♦.

Partner's 3♦ is a control bid showing the ♦A. Do not even consider that he is trying to get back to ♦s, you both know that your suit is ♠s.

NOW you use Blackwood, knowing you are not in danger of losing two quick ♦s.

Partner replies 5♥, showing two Aces.

Your side has all the Aces but don't get greedy. Remember that partner made a minimum bid at his second turn. He couldn't have two Aces and three Kings.

So you bid the small slam.

South plays 6♠. West leads the ♥Q.

South plays 6♠. West leads the ♥Q.

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 2

Too bad partner didn't have either ♥K or ♣K. But since he didn't you will just have to establish the ♦ suit.

You pull trumps in one round with your ♠K. Play ♦ A K, then ruff a ♦. if both defenders follow then both dummy's ♦s are good and you will make 7. However, it is more likely that ♦s will split 4-2, in which case you return to dummy with the ♠J and ruff the fourth ♦. Back to dummy with the ♠A and play the now-established ♦7, discarding either your ♥ or ♣ loser.

Establishing a long side suit in dummy is one of the basic ways to eliminate a loser.

Board 3
North Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 9 2 ♥ K Q J 10 6 3 ♦ 8 3 ♣ 9 6 2	
♠ 8 7 5 ♥ 9 7 4 ♦ Q 10 5 ♣ A Q 7 3	N W E S	♠ Q J 10 6 ♥ 8 ♦ K J 9 4 ♣ J 10 8 5
	♠ A K 4 3 ♥ A 5 2 ♦ A 7 6 2 ♣ K 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠Q

Wow! Partner opens with a 2-bid and you have all of this?

Don't get carried away, it was a **WEAK** 2-bid. So even though you have 19 points partner has only 6-11. But even though it is possible that the total only comes to 25 you bid the game anyway, figuring that it will probably be at least 26.

South would play 4♥.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠Q.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠Q.

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 3 : Total = 4

There are two ways to get rid of one of those ♣ losers. You can lead up to the ♣K, hoping that East holds ♣A, or you can ruff it in dummy.

Suppose you try to combine both chances. Win the ♠K, then play a small ♥ to your hand. Lead a ♣ and play dummy's ♣K. West takes the ♣A and plays another trump which you win in your hand. You play another ♣ but West wins this one also and leads another trump, removing dummy's last hope of ruffing a ♣. Down 1.

Instead you could give up on the idea of leading toward the ♣K and just lead a ♣ from dummy at trick 2. The defenders can win and lead a trump, but you play a second ♣. They win this also but even if they lead a trump you can still ruff your third ♣ in dummy and make the game.

You can see that playing a ♣ from dummy will guarantee the contract.

You can also see that leading a ♥ back to your hand at trick 2 is a bad idea.

But did you see there is another way to reach your hand? You could play ♠A then ruff a ♠. This runs the small risk that West started with a singleton ♠.

Board 4
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q 9 2 ♥ 8 5 4 ♦ A 6 3 ♣ 7 5 4 2	
♠ 7 5 3 ♥ Q 10 7 6 ♦ K Q J ♣ Q 10 8		♠ A 6 ♥ J 9 ♦ 10 8 7 4 2 ♣ K J 9 3
	♠ K J 10 8 4 ♥ A K 3 2 ♦ 9 5 ♣ A 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♠
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♦
Pass	3♠		
All Pass			

3♠ by South
Lead: ♦K

With 6 points you must respond. And with 3 ♠s you can support partner's suit.

You respond 2♠ and partner bids 3♦.

Partner's 3♦ bid is a Help Suit Game Try. He is inviting you to bid game if you have a good 2♠ response, particularly if you can help him in ♦s.

Although have the ♦ help you have a bare minimum response. So you return to 3 ♠ which partner passes.

North would play 3♠.

South plays 3♠. West leads the ♦K.

South plays 3♠. West leads the ♦K.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 5

The ♦ loser, the ♣ loser and the Ace of trumps are unavoidable. One ♥ loser is also unavoidable, but the second one can be ruffed in dummy. You cannot afford to play a single trump.

Win the ♦A and play ♥A, ♥K, ♥2. The defenders will win this. If your ♥3 happened to set up then you won't have to ruff it, but more than likely the ♥s split 4-2. The defenders may now take a ♦ winner, or they may lead ♠A and another ♠. But they cannot stop you from ruffing your fourth ♥ with dummy's ♠Q or ♠9.

The defenders may not lead trumps to try to stop your ruff.

In that case you must be sure to ruff the fourth ♥ with the ♠Q or the ♠9. If East wants to over-ruff it will be with the ♠A which you must lose anyway.

Look at what would have happened if you had led a trump at trick 2. East could have won the ♠A and played another ♠. Then, when West took the third ♥ he could lead his last ♠ and dummy would have no trump to ruff the final ♥ with.